



Communicating Trade-Offs

Week 6 • Day 3 • Stakeholder Alignment & Negotiation

TPM Academy



Day 3 Objectives

- Translate a technical trade-off — say, an SLO (Service Level Objective) budget — into the **stakeholder's currency**
- Apply the "**need to know vs need to decide**" frame
- Write a **1-page brief** that fits on one page (the constraint is forcing)
- Predict the stakeholder's **top 5 questions**
- Cross-review in role + AI-critique to surface gaps



Today's Shape

Clock	Block	Outcome
09:00 – 09:15	Opening	Pin SEP Sections 1–2 + TCD Section 5 trade-offs on the wall
09:15 – 10:30	Block 1 + Activity 1	Translation drill (6 examples)
10:45 – 12:00	Block 2 + Activity 2	Pick trade-off + stakeholder + predict 5 questions
13:00 – 14:15	Block 3 + Activity 3	Draft the 1-page brief
14:30 – 16:00	Block 4 + Activity 4 + Wrap	Cross-review (in role) + AI critique

Block 1 — The Translation Discipline

Same trade-off, expressed in their currency



Translation Is Re-Framing

Technical framing	Business framing
"Async write to audit; sync would breach p95"	"Ship 50ms faster; audit logs lag 10s. Important for Q3 compliance review timing."
"Denormalized ticket_ids array"	"Optimizing reconcile reads at the cost of a future query type. We'd revisit if that query becomes hot."
"Modular monolith, not a service"	"Shipping faster by not separating this code; we accept the cost of a future split if traffic grows 5x."

Currency by stakeholder: CFO → cost. Customer Success → customer outcome. Compliance → regulatory exposure. Eng Director → velocity.

"Need to Know" vs "Need to Decide"

Need to know

- Headline outcome
- Cost we're accepting
- Trigger to revisit
- What we need from them

Need to decide

- Approve the choice?
- Cost acceptable?
- Trigger well-chosen?
- Provide what we need?

Strip everything else. Detail goes in the appendix or "available on request."

Activity 1 — Translation Drill

Quads • 45 minutes

6 technical statements, each paired with a stakeholder. Pick 3; translate each.

- 5 min: pick 3 of the 6
- 30 min: translate using audience currency
- 10 min: critique the translations (would the stakeholder act?)



5 + 30 + 10

Block 2 — Pick + Predict

Trade-off + stakeholder + their first 5 questions



Picking the Pairing

Pick criteria	What this means
Decision-shaped	There's a real call to make
Stakeholder has power	They can approve or block
Non-obvious cost	Needs explaining

5 predicted questions: at least one should be hostile. If all 5 are friendly, you're not stress-testing.



Decision-Shaped — or Not?

A real call ✓

"Accept a 10-sec audit lag to keep writes async?"

"Modular monolith, or a new service?"

"Active-passive or active-active across regions?"

Not a decision ✗

"We should have good performance"

"Let's follow best practices"

"Make it reliable"

If the stakeholder can't say **yes** or **no** to it, it's not a trade-off brief — it's a status update. Pick the one with a real call and a non-obvious cost.

Right Call → Right Person

Pull the stakeholder from your **SEP Section 1** map. Match the *kind* of call to whoever owns it — and aim for a **high-power** quadrant (they can actually approve or block).

Trade-off	Who owns the call
Async audit write (10-sec lag)	Compliance Lead
Modular monolith vs. new service	Architect
Denormalize <code>ticket_ids</code>	Eng Director
Active-passive vs. active-active	CFO + Architect

Predict Their First 5 Questions

- **Rank by likelihood** — what do they ask *first*, not eventually?
- **Speak their currency** — the CFO asks "what's the dollar number?"; Compliance asks "what's our exposure?"
- **At least one hostile** — if all 5 are friendly, you haven't stress-tested the brief.

Worked example — CFO on active-active: "What does it cost per year?" · "What actually breaks if we stay active-passive?" · "Who else is asking for this?" · "What's the revenue at risk?" · "Can we defer it a quarter?"

Activity 2 — Pick + Predict

Quads • 50 minutes

- 5 min: review Technical Concept Document (TCD) Section 5 + Technical Modeling Document (TMD) trade-offs
- 10 min: pick the trade-off
- 10 min: pick the stakeholder
- 25 min: predict 5 questions, ranked, with at least 1 hostile



5 + 10 + 10 + 25

Block 3 — Draft the 1-Page Brief

The 1-page constraint is forcing



The 1-Page Template

```
# Trade-off brief: <feature>
**For:** <stakeholder> | **From:** <quad> | **Date:** ...

## The decision (1 sentence)
We are choosing [X] over [Y], accepting [cost].

## Why this matters to you (1-2 sentences in their currency)
...

## The choice
- What we're doing: ...
- What we're explicitly NOT doing: ...
- The cost we're accepting: ...

## What would change our mind
<concrete trigger>

## What we need from you
☐ Approval to proceed
☐ Specific concern to address
☐ Information we don't have

## Appendix (linked)
- TCD Section 5 / TMD SectionX / SLO budget
```



Worked Brief (Async Audit Write for Compliance)

The decision

Async audit write (1-10s lag) over synchronous to keep dispatcher reconcile screens fast.

Why this matters to you

Affects audit-trail timing your SOC 2 process depends on.
Audit events are still durable (Event Hubs stream + DLQ) – they just appear in audit store 1-10 seconds after the action.

The choice

- Doing: Publish to Event Hubs stream at user-action; consumer writes to audit store within 1-10s.
- NOT doing: Sync write on user's hot path (would add 30-80ms; breaks p95 SLO).
- Cost: A regulator querying within 5s of an event sees stale state.

What would change our mind

A regulator or customer contractually requires sync audit visibility within < 1 second.

What we need from you

- ☐ Approval that 1-10s lag is acceptable for SOC 2
- ☐ Confirmation of acceptable lag bound (we propose $\leq 10s$ p99)
- ☐ Note of any contract requiring sync audit (we know of none)

Activity 3 — Draft the Brief

Quads • 50 minutes

- 5 min: decision sentence
- 20 min: why this matters (cross-check vs predicted Q1)
- 10 min: doing / not doing / cost
- 5 min: change-our-mind trigger
- 5 min: what we need (specific checkboxes)
- 5 min: appendix linkbox (e.g., a DLQ — dead-letter queue — reference)



5 + 20 + 10 + 5 + 5 + 5

Block 4 — Cross-Review (in Role) + AI

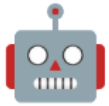
Read the brief as the stakeholder would

In-Role Reading

Reviewer quad reads the brief **as if they were the stakeholder**. They underline:

- Sentences that **lose them** (jargon, irrelevant, unclear)
- Sentences they'd **push back on**
- The **first question** they'd ask

Author quad listens; does not defend. Same Week-3 review discipline.



AI in Role

Role: <stakeholder type – CFO, Compliance Lead, Sales VP>

Context: <paste the brief>

Task: Read this as the named stakeholder.

- First question you'd ask?
- Concern that's unaddressed?
- Word or phrase that loses you?

Constraints:

- Specific to the brief, not generic
- Voice the stakeholder honestly

Format: Numbered – Question / Concern / Word.

Activity 4 — In-Role Review + AI

Quad pairs • 55 minutes • Wrap

- 10 min: reviewer quad reads in role; underlines
- 10 min: author quad listens to feedback
- 25 min: AI critique in role
- 10 min: adopt / defer / reject + update Section 3



10 + 10 + 25 + 10 • 15-min wrap



Day 3 Wrap

What we built

- Translation discipline (currency by stakeholder)
- "Need to know vs need to decide" frame
- 1-page brief for one trade-off + stakeholder
- Cross-reviewed in role + AI-critiqued
- Stakeholder Engagement Plan (SEP) Section 3 drafted

What opens tomorrow

- **AI-augmented requirement summaries**
- Meeting prep: prior context, predicted objections, opening
- Validation discipline (Wk 5 D5)

Bring to Day 4: SEP Sections 1–3. Tomorrow we prep for the Friday simulation using AI.

Questions & Reflection

Which trade-off in your TCD would you most want to brief tomorrow?